

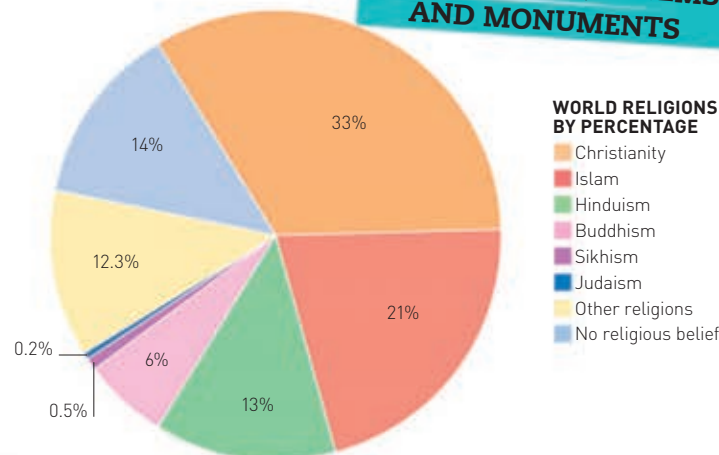
World religions

A religion is a collection of beliefs that attempts to explain the meaning of life. Most religions recognize a supreme power, usually a god or gods. There are many different faiths worldwide, most with their own laws and history set down in sacred books. The followers of a faith unite through prayer, rituals, and beliefs.

WHICH FAITH?

Christianity is the largest of the world religions. The number of followers of any religion changes all the time, as people decide to join or leave a faith, or to convert from one to another.

RELIGION CAN BE TRACED BACK TO THE STONE AGE, THROUGH SUCH EVIDENCE AS BURIAL SITES, TOTEMS, AND MONUMENTS



SYMBOL
Cross

CHRISTIANITY

Christians believe in one God and in his son, Jesus Christ. Their holy text, the Bible, tells how Jesus was born on Earth to be the saviour of humankind. His teachings gave rise to Christianity, of which there are various branches. These include the Protestant, Roman Catholic, and Orthodox churches. Each has a different form of worship, but they all pray to the same God.



ICONS
The Orthodox Christian church uses icons – often paintings such as this one of the infant Christ with his mother Mary – as a focus for prayers.



ST PETER'S SQUARE
The square lies at the heart of the Vatican City, in Rome, where the Pope, head of the Catholic Church, lives.

CANTERBURY CATHEDRAL
This English cathedral is one of the oldest and most important Christian buildings in the world.



SYMBOL
Letter for the sacred sound "OM"

HINDUISM

There are hundreds of millions of Hindus worldwide. Their religion includes many gods and goddesses, the greatest being Brahma. Hindus believe in reincarnation: the cycle of life, death, and rebirth that continues until the soul is set free. Most of them worship by saying individual prayers, and do not attend communal services, although they join together at festivals.



GANESH
Elephant-headed
Ganesh is the Hindu god of learning and new ventures.



NADI TEMPLE
Hindu temples are built in many styles. This one is the Nadi temple in Fiji.



KRISHNA
Usually shown with blue skin, Krishna is one of the best-loved Hindu gods.



SYMBOL
Crescent and star

ISLAM

The people who belong to this religion are called Muslims. They live according to the Five Pillars of Islam: faith, prayer, fasting, alms-giving, and pilgrimage. Their holy book is the Qur'an, which contains the word of the one Muslim God, Allah, as told to the Prophet Muhammad. Muslims pray at five set times every day. On Fridays, Muslims gather for prayers at a mosque.



FACING MECCA
At prayer, Muslims kneel facing the direction of the holy city of Mecca, to which all aim to make a pilgrimage.

JUMEIRAH MOSQUE
The mosque is the centre of a Muslim community – a place for people to pray, meditate, and learn.



QUR'AN
In this copy of the Qur'an the text is surrounded by ornate borders.



SYMBOL
Wheel of law

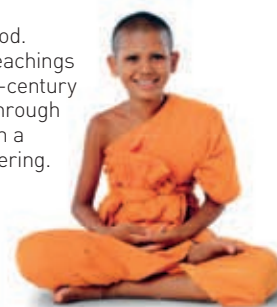
BUDDHISM

Buddhists do not worship a single, creator god. They follow a way of thinking based on the teachings of Siddhartha Gautama, born a prince in 5th-century India, who became known as the Buddha. Through recurring lifecycles, Buddhists hope to reach a state called Nirvana – freedom from all suffering.



STUPA
Dome-shaped mounds called stupas were built all over Asia to house Buddhist relics. This one is in Sri Lanka.

GIANT BUDDHA
This giant-sized statue of the Buddha in Uva Province, Sri Lanka, is carved from solid rock.



BUDDHIST NOVICE
Boys as young as seven years may enter Buddhist monasteries as trainees, or novices.



PRAYER FLAGS
Buddhist flags, fluttering in the mountains of Nepal, carry prayers into the wind.